

Sourdough Fermentation

The mechanics of sourdough fermentation depend on a stable culture of wild yeast and lactic acid bacteria living in rough equilibrium. Bakers who keep a starter for years are really maintaining a small ecosystem, feeding it flour and water on a schedule that suits their kitchen temperature.

Hydration matters more than most beginners expect. A wetter dough develops an open, irregular crumb because the gas produced during proofing can push the gluten network further before it sets. A stiffer dough gives a tighter, more even structure, which some people prefer for sandwiches.

Timing is the part that resists precise instruction. Ambient temperature swings of even a few degrees change how quickly the dough proofs, so recipes that specify exact hours tend to mislead. Experienced bakers read the dough instead: how it domes, how it springs back, whether the surface has gone slack.